

Event Timeline Sequencing Methodology

Point vs. Span: A Consistent Rule for Placing Narrative Events on a Timeline

1. The Problem This Solves

When you extract events from a narrative and try to place them on a numeric timeline (e.g., 0–90), every event needs a **Start** and an **End** position. The question that causes the most disagreement between annotators is:

Should this event be a single point in time, or should it stretch across a range?

Different annotators will answer this differently for the same sentence unless there's a shared rule. This document describes the rule we converged on, why the alternatives failed, and how to apply it consistently.

2. The Core Rule

An event is a POINT if it describes a single occurrence — an action that happened once, at one time — even if that action has lasting consequences.

An event is a SPAN only if the text itself explicitly frames it as a duration or a continuing/recurring state — using language like "for X years," "since," "still," "every year," "over the next two days," "never," "always," or a stated start-and-end.

The test to ask of every event:

"Is this sentence describing an action, or a state?"

- **Action** (moved, arrived, called, bought, died, decided, told, scattered, walked, graduated) → **POINT**, regardless of how long the effects of that action last afterward.
 - **State, explicitly marked as ongoing/durational** (*"had been living there for two years," "still sold the same rolls," "had not slept since," "every Friday for thirty years," "never returned"*) → **SPAN**, covering the actual duration described.
-

3. Why This Matters (The Failure Mode We Were Avoiding)

The tempting-but-wrong approach is: *"well, technically the consequences of this action are still true, so let's span it to the end."*

Under that logic, almost **everything** becomes a wide span running to the end of the timeline — a person's job, their move to a new city, a friendship, a marriage — because nothing in a story is ever really "over." This collapses the whole point of a timeline: it stops distinguishing **what is actively happening in the story's present** from **background facts that explain why**

Example of the mistake, and the fix:

"Imran had moved away from Wari to Mirpur eight months ago for his new job."

- ❌ Wrong (span to present): reasoning "he still lives there, so the move's effects are ongoing." This treats an action as if it were a state.
 - ✅ Correct (point, 8 months before the story's present): the *moving* happened once, on one day. That it has lasting consequences (he now lives elsewhere) doesn't make the *event* durational — it makes the *consequence* durational, and the consequence isn't what you're plotting unless the text separately says so ("he still lives there," "he continues to...").
-

4. Worked Examples

Sentence	Verdict	Why
"Her father had died when she was two."	Point	One-time action; depth in the past doesn't change this.
"The tournament had been held every year for as long as anyone could remember."	Span (full range)	Recurring pattern, explicitly unbounded ("as long as anyone could remember").
"She had not slept since leaving the previous night."	Span (from leaving to the moment mentioned)	The <i>not-sleeping</i> is itself the durational content — the sentence is describing a state, not an action.

"A professor she had met at a seminar six months before the trip."	Point	A single meeting. "Six months before" only tells you <i>when</i> the point falls, not that it's a duration.
"The shop had been open since 1987 and was finally closing."	Span (full lifespan)	The shop's operation is a genuine continuing state with a real start and end.
"He had started a part-time job at a pharmacy."	Point	Starting a job is a one-time action, even though the job (presumably) continued — unless the text separately says "and still works there."
"She had lived in Kuala Lumpur for two years on a work visa."	Span	Explicit stated duration ("for two years"), with a real end (when she leaves KL).
"He mentioned it during a phone call two days earlier."	Point	One occurrence.

5. Handling "Compound" Sentences (Action + Later Reveal)

A common trap: a sentence describes a one-time past action, but the *reveal* of that fact happens later.

"He had already wired money for the wedding from Saudi Arabia five weeks ago but had kept it secret to surprise everyone [revealed at dinner tonight]."

Don't merge "wiring the money" and "revealing it at dinner" into one wide span running from five weeks ago to tonight — that conflates two separate one-time actions into a false duration.

Do pick one of these, depending on what your labeling scheme actually needs to represent:

- Treat it as a **single point** at whichever moment matters more for your analysis (usually the reveal, since that's when it affects the story).
- If your framework allows it, split it into **two separate point-events**: (a) the wiring, dated five weeks ago, and (b) the telling, dated tonight.

What you should *not* do is let "the fact was true throughout that gap" turn into "therefore it's a span" — truth persisting isn't the same as the event being durational.

6. Handling Deep-Past Background Facts

Stories often include background facts far outside the story's active timeframe (a grandfather's career decades ago, a building's construction date, a family history). These still get sequenced — usually as very early points or narrow spans near position 0 — but they should **not** be allowed to stretch all the way to the present just because they're "still relevant" or "still true" in some loose sense. Apply the same action/state test:

- "A mango tree her grandfather had planted forty years ago still stood." → **Span**, because "still stood" is an explicit present-tense continuing state.
 - "A photograph taken in 1971" found inside a box today → **Point**, at the moment of *discovery*, not a span reaching back to 1971 — taking a photograph is a one-time action; its physical existence afterward isn't what's being tracked.
-

7. Quick Checklist Before Assigning Start/End

1. Find the main verb. Is it an action verb (moved, told, bought, died, arrived) or a state description (had been, still, since, every)?
 2. If action → **point**. Place it at the moment it occurred, however far in the past.
 3. If state → check for **explicit durational language** ("for X years," "since," "still," "never," "always," "every," a stated start and end). If present → **span**, bounded by whatever start/end the text gives (or implies clearly).
 4. If a sentence mixes an action and a later consequence/reveal, don't merge them into one span — treat the action as its own point and decide separately whether the reveal needs its own point or ID.
 5. When genuinely unsure, default to **point** — spans should be the exception, justified by explicit language, not the default assumption.
-

8. Copy-Paste Context Block for an AI Assistant

Give your thesis mates (or their own AI tools) the block below as-is. It's self-contained and doesn't depend on this document's examples.

TASK: Event Timeline Sequencing (Point vs. Span Method)

When assigning Start/End positions to extracted narrative events on a numeric timeline, apply this rule consistently:

RULE: An event is a **POINT** (narrow Start/End, essentially one position) if it describes a single occurrence — an action that happened once — even if that action has lasting consequences. An event is a **SPAN** (Start and End meaningfully apart) **ONLY** if the sentence explicitly frames it as a duration or a continuing/recurring state, using language such as: "for X years," "since," "still," "never," "always," "every [time period]," "over the next [period]," or an explicit stated start and end.

TEST TO APPLY TO EVERY EVENT:

Ask: "Is this sentence describing an **ACTION** or a **STATE**?"

- Action (moved, arrived, called, bought, died, decided, told, scattered, walked, graduated, started) -> **POINT**, regardless of how long the effects last afterward.
- State, explicitly marked as ongoing/durational -> **SPAN**, covering the actual described duration.

DO NOT treat "the consequences of this action are still true" as justification for a span. Only explicit durational/continuing language in the text justifies a span. When in doubt, default to **POINT**.

COMPOUND SENTENCES (action + later reveal): do not merge a one-time past action with the later moment it is revealed/discussed into one wide span. Either pick the single most relevant moment as a point, or represent the two moments as two separate point-events if your schema allows it.

DEEP-PAST BACKGROUND FACTS: sequence them as early points or narrow spans near the start of the timeline. Only extend them toward the present if the text uses explicit present-continuing language (e.g., "still stood," "never returned"). A fact merely being "still relevant" is not sufficient — apply the same action/state test.

When presenting your reasoning, briefly state for each event: (1) whether you classified it as a point or span, and (2) the specific word or phrase in the text that justifies that classification. If no such phrase exists, default to point and say so explicitly.

9. Summary in One Sentence

Plot the action where it happened, not where its effects still linger — and only stretch an event into a span when the text itself is describing a duration, not when you can imagine one.